BOOKS

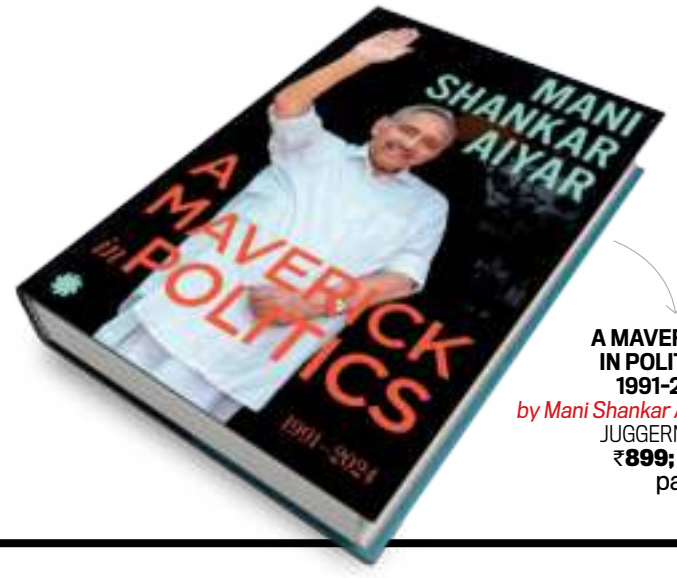
The Road Less Travelled

***A Maverick in Politics* by Mani Shankar Aiyar offers instructive ringside lessons in mainstream Indian politics**

Even to an ex-IFS civil servant watching from the sidelines, the publication of the third volume of Mani Shankar Aiyar's autobiography (if you count his second book on Rajiv Gandhi also as a memoir), *A Maverick in Politics*, covering his political career and life from 1991 to 2024, must rank as an event in political biography in India. Part self-defence in the court of public opinion, part confessional, part living historical record, it is unusual in many ways.

First, there are not many like Mani in public or political life, a product of a well-to-do if tragedy-prone apolitical family, with an elite education and career who joined a vocation where caste, social and political moorings are more typical than qualifications or the principles of socialism, secularism and internationalism that he passionately espoused.

Second, his wit, irreverence and willingness to cross swords for party and principle on the one hand, and on the other, his candour, intellectual integrity and ability to look at himself in the mirror in an ethical jungle better known for its venality, opportunism, corruption and hypocrisy. Mani just could not pretend to be what he is not.



A MAVERICK IN POLITICS 1991-2024
by Mani Shankar Aiyar
JUGGERNAUT
₹899; 428 pages

BOOKS

A MOMENT OF TRIUMPH

Amitabh Kant's *How India Scaled Mt G20* provides an insider's view of India's G20 presidency

India's G20 presidency was a striking success both internationally and domestically. Prime Minister Narendra Modi seized the opportunity to showcase rising India with all its diversity to the world, and also involve the country at large in celebrating this "coming out party". Our presidency was converted into a massive national event, and consistent with India's global foreign affairs vision of friendship with all, was purposefully given a civilisational character by its theme: "Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam–One Earth, One Family, One Future".

Our media coverage of the event was commensurately massive, before, during and after, reaching saturation point. Amitabh Kant has himself commented extensively in public on the organisational and negotiating challenges that India faced and the herculean efforts made to achieve success. Notwithstanding all this, in choosing to write the book, Kant has wanted to give the readers a comprehensive and definitive view from inside the eye of the storm, as it were.

Amongst the goals of India's presidency was to shift the G20 agenda away from the priorities of the

How India succeeded in producing a consensus document despite acute differences on Ukraine is the most engrossing part of the book

